In those ancient times, those long-forgotten times, before the first fire-winds carried red-black dust from the world's many-notched belt, before the smell of bread rose in shimmering heat from the first yellow brick ovens. Before the first olives were pressed to drink and cook and cast light, before the first figs were crushed and chopped to make sweetness. Before the first kings and queens ventured forth to know all the lands, and to see the comings and goings of its creatures, and to foretell the flooding and thirsting of its rivers. Before the first saints were born in the deserts above the many-notched belt, and before they gave the authority from heaven to rule the world to the leaders of our people. Before all things, our ancestors came from the stars. Theirs was an empire of a thousand-thousand suns, and their mandate was carried in song. The world was at peace and in balance for as long as the song was sung. And sung was the song for a thousand-thousand years, when all the things which are to come already came to pass. And through the singing, all of the affairs of all the creatures of the universe were conducted and concluded, and reopened again, and all the words were spoken and written in all the arrangements they could adopt. And the song was sung until there was no more song to sing. And the empire of a thousand-thousand suns became a thousand-thousand strangers, alone in the dark and quiet. That is how we have come to live on Hiraeth until we find the heart to sing the song again.

In prehistoric times, Hiraeth was inhabited by a star-faring civilization known as the Dreamers. Their fate is largely ambiguous, but they are believed to have died out before humanity was born.

When humanity is born, they discover magic on a far-away world, which they use to construct something called "The Song," a network of power and knowledge used to traverse between planets and stars. Humanity becomes the dominant force in the universe for a long time, but when The Song suddenly fails, everyone finds themselves stranded and isolated.

In the chaos following the loss of The Song, most developed societies are destroyed or greatly set back by wars to control what is left of the stockpiled interstellar resources and technology. Most societies revert back to decentralized agrarian cultures, or nomadic hunter-gatherers, ecology permitting.

Along the equator (the many-notched belt), a particular group of humans, called Morivians, discover the process of Eternal Sainthood, and create the Trivinian Temple. The three Trivinian saints synthesize advanced knowledge of the planet and its ruined technology, allowing the Morivians to advance rapidly.

Creeping climate disaster makes the equator uninhabitable, forcing the Morivians to venture North and South. They establish powerful empires in both hemispheres by exploiting their unmatched access to and understanding of technology. Both empires, however, lose contact when the equator becomes too hostile to even traverse, and the Northern Empire greatly declines without the support of its southern twin.

The northern hemisphere is a relatively small basin with a few connected seas. Hiraeth is ecologically very arid, and life is concentrated around the coasts and very productive riverlands. Most of the world's rivers originate from a relatively stable ice-cap on the north pole.

In an attempt to preserve itself, the Northern Empire has split itself into various courts, which appoint a local king to administer different regions (courts essentially = provinces). While still powerful and geographically dominant, the empire is a shadow of its former self and its rulers are aware they are losing their grip.

The Trivinian Temple has become the dominant religion throughout the Northern hemisphere, and represents the Empire's strongest form of soft power. The three living saints are pretty much universally revered, even among non-humans, because they are uniquely capable of affecting positive change throughout the world.

In recent years, the Empire endured a long and costly civil war which saw a number major shakeups:

- An Askanian walking city was killed for the first time.
- The Court of Half Truths has fallen outside of the Empire's control, overrun by Va'a nomads.
- The River Court lost control of the Vallon woods to the Redwood, creating a Shei diaspora.

- The Empire conquered the kingdom of Kesh, placing the living saint Vespera as its ruler and integrating it as the Sister Court. Saint Vespera is in the process of quickly dying and will need to be replaced soon.
- The old Emperor is dead and his son is facing his first constitutional session, a once-per-decade legislative event where representatives from around the empire haggle over details and collectively rewrite the constitution.

About the Saints:

- Sainthood is hereditary. The temple grooms promising orphans from birth to perfectly imitate and replace the "original" saint. These potential saints are called Armigers and they are shut away in isolation from the world. Classes of hundreds are kept at a time, so the absolute perfect candidate can be discovered and curated. As a child armiger ages and begins to diverge from the expected sainthood, they are typically incorporated into the temple bureaucracy.
- Saints get stronger as they age, until they die very suddenly. Their knowledge arrives to them as "memories," allowing them to recognize and interpret symbols and patterns in ancient ruins and make use of the ruins' secrets. This knowledge accumulates over time.
- The three saints are: Vespera the Lover, dispenser of strategy, protection, fertility, and worldly cleverness, Trinivar the Mage, dispenser of truth, esoteric knowledge, and metaphysical cleverness, and Sallus Ven the Poet, dispenser of beauty, art, subjective knowledge, and spiritual cleverness.
- Saints are created and propagated through the ingestion of prion-like proteins which store the suspended mental state of ancient Dreamers. For Dreamer biology, this would essentially work like mind-melding, but incompatibility with human neural architecture results in severe neurodegeneration. Saints develop neural attractor states that simulate the memory and recognition of Dreamer ruins, but overwrite their own memories in the process. Over time this cascades into erasing motor executive function, causing saints to rediscover deep truths about the world and the history of the universe, but suffer from nonstop seizures until they basically forget how to breathe and die.